

A Closed Hospital, a Fatal Heart Attack, and a \$50 Billion Fund That Can't Help

From: NPR Health Mined: 2026-05-23 5 min read

WILLIAMSTON, N.C. Debra Pierce stands in the overgrown yard of her late brother's mobile home, clutching his photo. Stanley Sears was 50 when he suffered a heart attack in 2024. Emergency crews from a neighboring town worked on him for 30 minutes but couldn't revive him for the 20-mile drive to the closest hospital. 'The sad thing is we'll never know if he could have been saved that night,' Pierce says.

Martin County's only hospital, Martin General, had closed **abruptly** a year earlier. The shutdown stunned employees and patients some were wheeled out on stretchers mid-treatment. The operating company, Quorum Health, filed for **bankruptcy** without notifying local officials, they say. Since then, the county has poured an estimated \$2.9 million into maintaining the empty building, hoping to reopen it.

Now, a \$50 billion rural health fund part of the One Big Beautiful Bill Act is being touted by Republicans as a lifeline for communities like this. North Carolina is **earmarked** for \$213 million. But Martin County won't see a dime. Federal rules limit construction spending, and the money flows only to existing health organizations. 'The \$50 billion is not something that is specifically going to help our situation,' says County Manager Drew Batts. 'It's not going to help us get this place reopened.'

The healthcare gaps are stark. Martin County has no **paramedics** on its ambulances. The nearest ERs are often overcrowded. The region's **safety net** is ECU Health, a nine-hospital system connected to East Carolina University, but it's stretched thin across 29 counties.

Pierce, a Republican, still has faith in President Trump. 'Old man's doing his job up in there,' she says. But her hope now rests on a county plan to spend at least \$1.5 million to create two advanced paramedic units with quick-response vehicles and lifesaving equipment like **electrocardiograms**. 'There's some answered prayers happening every day,' she says. 'So, we can only pray and hope, you know?' For Stanley Sears, it's a hope that came too late.

Word Treasure

abruptly -- Suddenly and without warning; in this case, the hospital closed with almost no notice.

bankruptcy -- A legal process where a company declares it cannot pay its debts and asks for court protection.

earmarked -- Set aside or designated for a specific purpose; here, a share of the huge fund was reserved for North Carolina.

paramedics -- Trained emergency medical professionals who can provide advanced life support before reaching a hospital.

electrocardiograms -- Machines that record the electrical activity of a person's heart, helping doctors detect heart problems quickly.

safety net -- A system or organization that provides essential help to people who might otherwise fall through the cracks.

Background you need

Rural hospital closures have become a crisis across the United States, with more than 100 facilities shutting down in the past decade. Many small-town hospitals struggle financially because they serve poorer, older populations and have fewer patients with private insurance. This forces communities to rely on distant emergency rooms, sometimes with deadly delays.

The One Big Beautiful Bill Act, proposed by Republican lawmakers, included a \$50 billion fund meant to rescue rural health care. However, strict rules in the legislation limit how the money can be used -- it cannot directly rebuild closed hospitals and only goes to existing health organizations. As a result, places like Martin County, which lost its only hospital, are left without support.

ECU Health (the nonprofit health system linked to East Carolina University) provides a safety net across 29 largely rural counties, but it is stretched thin. Meanwhile, Martin County officials are taking matters into their own hands, planning to invest in mobile advanced paramedic units to reduce response times.

Break it down

LEAD: Personal story -- Debra Pierce lost her brother because the nearest hospital was too far away.

HOSPITAL CLOSURE:

- + Martin General closed abruptly when operator Quorum Health declared bankruptcy.
- + The county is now spending millions just to maintain the empty building.

FEDERAL FUNDING GAP:

- + A \$50 billion rural health fund was created, but...
- + Martin County can't access it because of restrictions on construction and a requirement to fund only existing organizations.

CURRENT REALITY:

- + Ambulances lack paramedics,
- + The regional safety-net system ECU Health is overwhelmed.

PERSONAL FAITH: Pierce, a Republican, still supports President Trump but pins her hopes on a local plan.

FORWARD-LOOKING: The county wants to spend \$1.5 million on two advanced paramedic units with life-saving equipment.

CLOSING THOUGHT: The effort comes too late to save Stanley Sears.

Why it matters

This story reveals a hidden but widespread problem: even when large sums of money are allocated to fix rural health care, flawed rules can prevent the most desperate communities from receiving any help. For a 13-year-old, it's a real-life example of how policy decisions directly affect who lives and who dies.

Test what you remember

1. Why did Martin General Hospital close?

- ☐ (A) It was destroyed by a natural disaster
- ☐ (B) The operating company filed for bankruptcy without warning
- ☐ (C) The county government voted to shut it down
- ☐ (D) It merged with a larger hospital system

2. How far is the drive from where Stanley Sears had his heart attack to the nearest hospital?

- ☐ (A) 10 miles
- ☐ (B) 20 miles
- ☐ (C) 30 miles
- ☐ (D) 50 miles

3. Why can't Martin County get money from the \$50 billion rural health fund?

- ☐ (A) The county missed the application deadline
- ☐ (B) The state of North Carolina rejected the request
- ☐ (C) Federal rules restrict spending on construction and require existing health organizations
- ☐ (D) The fund is only for research, not for reopening hospitals

4. What does Martin County currently lack on its ambulances?

- ☐ (A) Basic bandages
- ☐ (B) Electrocardiograms
- ☐ (C) Paramedics
- ☐ (D) Oxygen tanks

5. What is ECU Health?

- ☐ (A) A private insurance company
- ☐ (B) A nine-hospital safety-net system connected to East Carolina University
- ☐ (C) A pharmaceutical manufacturer serving rural areas
- ☐ (D) A government agency that runs rural clinics

6. What does the county plan to spend at least \$1.5 million on?

- ☐ (A) Rebuilding the hospital
- ☐ (B) Purchasing new ambulances with paramedics
- ☐ (C) Creating two advanced paramedic units with quick-response vehicles
- ☐ (D) Lobbying the government to change the funding rules

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: C 4: C 5: B 6: C

1. **Positive:** The county government is not giving up. Its plan to invest in advanced paramedic units shows local leadership taking action where federal help fails. If successful, it could become a model for other rural areas without hospitals.
2. **Negative / critical:** The \$50 billion fund is poorly designed. By preventing money from being used to reopen closed hospitals and limiting it to existing organizations, lawmakers made it useless for the very places that need it most. The abrupt closure also raises questions about corporate responsibility when Quorum Health filed for bankruptcy without notifying the community.
3. **Neutral / analytical:** The gap between policy intent and implementation is a recurring pattern in government programs. Rules meant to prevent misuse of funds can create rigid barriers that overlook real-world emergencies. This case illustrates the difficulty of designing federal aid that can adapt to unpredictable local catastrophes.
4. **Forward-looking:** The outrage from stories like this may pressure Congress to rewrite the rules, allowing direct hospital reconstruction in the future. Alternatively, towns might increasingly turn to mobile health units and telemedicine, reshaping rural emergency care away from large centralized buildings.